

LECTURE POINTS

DEMOCRACY IN PAKISTAN (1947 – Recent Government Tenure)

1. WHAT IS DEMOCRACY?

Democracy means **rule of the people**. It is a system in which sovereignty belongs to citizens and authority is exercised through elected representatives.

The word comes from Greek:

- *Demos* = People
- *Kratos* = Rule

In democratic systems:

- Governments are elected through free and fair elections.
- Leaders are accountable.
- Constitution is supreme.
- Fundamental rights are protected.
- Institutions function independently.

Core Principles of Democracy

1. Popular Sovereignty

People are the ultimate source of authority.

2. Rule of Law

Law applies equally to all — Prime Minister, military chief, judge, and citizen.

3. Constitutional Supremacy

No institution is above the Constitution.

4. Separation of Powers

Executive, Legislature, and Judiciary operate independently.

5. Political Pluralism

Opposition parties are allowed and respected.

6. Accountability & Transparency

Government decisions can be questioned.

In Pakistan, democracy operates under the **1973 Constitution**, which establishes a parliamentary system.

2. TYPES OF DEMOCRACY

(1) Direct Democracy

Citizens vote directly on laws.

Example: Referendums in Switzerland.

Not feasible in Pakistan due to large population.

(2) Representative Democracy

Citizens elect representatives.

Pakistan's institutions include:

- National Assembly
- Senate
- Provincial Assemblies

(3) Social Democracy

Ensures economic justice along with political rights.

Example: Ehsaas Program introduced under Imran Khan to support poor families.

HISTORICAL DEVELOPMENT OF DEMOCRACY IN PAKISTAN

3. EARLY YEARS (1947–1958)

Challenges After Independence

Pakistan inherited:

- Refugee crisis
- Weak economy
- Kashmir War (1947–48)
- Lack of experienced administrators

Vision of Muhammad Ali Jinnah

He emphasized:

- Equality of citizenship
- Parliamentary democracy
- Religious freedom

His death in 1948 created a leadership vacuum.

Political Instability (1951–1958)

After assassination of Liaquat Ali Khan, instability increased.

Six Prime Ministers ruled in seven years:

1. Khawaja Nazimuddin
2. Muhammad Ali Bogra
3. Chaudhry Muhammad Ali
4. H.S. Suhrawardy
5. I.I. Chundrigar
6. Feroz Khan Noon

Frequent dissolutions weakened parliamentary culture.

1956 Constitution & Collapse

Pakistan became Islamic Republic with parliamentary system.

In 1958:

Iskander Mirza abrogated constitution.

Then:

Ayub Khan imposed Martial Law.

First democratic breakdown.

4. AYUB KHAN ERA (1958–1969)

- 1962 Constitution (Presidential system).
- Basic Democracies system.
- Economic growth but political repression.
- East Pakistan marginalized.

Mass protests forced resignation.

5. YAHYA KHAN & 1971 BREAKUP

Yahya Khan held 1970 elections.

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman won majority.

Power not transferred → Civil war → Bangladesh created.

6. BHUTTO ERA (1971–1977)

Zulfikar Ali Bhutto

Major Achievement: 1973 Constitution

- Parliamentary system.
- Fundamental rights.

- Federalism.

However:

- Centralization of power.
- Opposition suppression.
- 1977 election controversy → coup.

7. ZIA-UL-HAQ ERA (1977–1988)

Zia-ul-Haq

- Martial Law.
- Islamization.
- 8th Amendment (President could dismiss PM).

Democracy structurally weakened.

8. DECADE OF DEMOCRACY (1988–1999)

After Zia's death in 1988, elections restored civilian rule.

However, democracy remained fragile due to:

- Article 58(2)(b)
- Civil-military imbalance
- Political polarization
- Corruption allegations
- Weak institutional maturity

Four governments were dismissed during this decade.

BENAZIR BHUTTO – FIRST TENURE (1988–1990)

Benazir Bhutto

Political Context

- PPP formed government without clear majority.
- Ghulam Ishaq Khan retained presidential powers.
- Military influence remained strong.

Major Initiatives

- Restoration of civil liberties.
- Women police stations.
- Focus on social development.
- Diplomatic outreach.

Challenges

- Weak coalition.
- President's dismissal powers.
- Limited control over security.
- Ethnic unrest in Sindh.
- Corruption allegations.

Dismissed in 1990.

NAWAZ SHARIF – FIRST TENURE (1990–1993)

Nawaz Sharif

Economic Focus

- Privatization.
- Market reforms.
- Infrastructure planning.

Political Conflict

Clash with President Ghulam Ishaq Khan led to constitutional crisis.

Both resigned in 1993 under military mediation.

BENAZIR BHUTTO – SECOND TENURE (1993–1996)

Benazir Bhutto

Policy Measures

- Telecom expansion.
- Energy projects.
- Women development.

Security Issues

- Karachi violence.
- Sectarianism.

Dismissed in 1996 by Farooq Leghari.

NAWAZ SHARIF – SECOND TENURE (1997–1999)

Nawaz Sharif

Major Reforms

- 13th Amendment (removed President's dismissal powers).
- 14th Amendment (party discipline).

Achievements

- Nuclear tests (1998).
- Infrastructure projects.

Crisis

- Judicial confrontation.
- Kargil conflict.
- Civil-military tension.

Coup by Pervez Musharraf in 1999.

Overall Assessment of Decade

- Elections held regularly.
- Democratic norms remained weak.
- Institutional imbalance persisted.
- Political intolerance high.

Democracy functioned electorally but not institutionally.

9. MUSHARRAF ERA (1999–2008)

- Centralized rule.
- 17th Amendment.
- Judicial crisis (2007).
- Lawyers' movement.

2008 elections restored democracy.

10. PPP GOVERNMENT (2008–2013)

Under Asif Ali Zardari

18th Amendment (2010)

- Parliamentary supremacy restored.
- Provincial autonomy strengthened.
- Presidential powers reduced.

Completed full term.

11. PML-N GOVERNMENT (2013–2018)

Nawaz Sharif

- CPEC projects.
- Energy improvements.
- Panama Papers → disqualification.

12. PTI GOVERNMENT (2018–2022)

Imran Khan

- Welfare reforms.
- Anti-corruption drive.
- IMF negotiations.
- Political polarization.

Removed via no-confidence vote.

13. PDM GOVERNMENT (2022–2023)

Shehbaz Sharif

- IMF stabilization.
- Flood crisis management.
- Inflation crisis.

14. 2024 ELECTIONS & CURRENT TENURE

2024 elections held.

Coalition formed.

Shehbaz Sharif became PM again.

Challenges:

- Economic crisis.
- Political polarization.
- Institutional tensions.

STRUCTURAL PROBLEMS

1. Military influence.
2. Weak party democracy.
3. Judicial activism.
4. Economic instability.
5. Elite dominance.
6. Political intolerance.

CONCLUSION

Pakistan's democracy has:

- Collapsed three times.
- Survived constitutional crises.
- Returned through elections repeatedly.

It remains:

Resilient but fragile.

Its future depends on:

- Constitutional supremacy.
- Civilian control.
- Economic reforms.
- Political tolerance.
- Institutional balance.